

Proposals as of June 21, 2019 from Our Dancers

About Gender-Free Role Terms

As we explore the question of gendered vs gender-free language, numerous dancers have made suggestions for possible ultimate outcomes, and others have made suggestions for how we might tackle the question. So many different ideas for us to consider! Here are the proposals that have already been made. We tried to include everything that people mentioned, although some of the descriptions were combined or streamlined to try to keep things digestible.

We hope to have all these suggestions shown on posters tacked up at the meetings.

Proposals for Outcomes

- 1) Switch to gender-free language for all our local dances. If we choose this option, we could use Larks and Ravens, Left and Right, Lead and Follow, Jets and Rubies, or some other gender-free terms.
- 2) Have our local callers use gendered language, and communicate to visiting callers that we use gendered language at our dances.
- 3) Allow each caller (individually) to use whatever language they prefer for role terminology (gendered or gender-free).
- 4) Allow each caller (individually) to use whatever language they prefer for role terminology (gendered or gender-free). Inform callers of the results of periodic polling, as in Process Item J, to inform their decisions, and ask callers to tell the community what the evening will look like. Try to keep this info current, but know that callers often switch.
- 5) Have some of our dances use gender-free language, and some dances use gendered language. These could be either single dances during an evening, or full evenings of dance. This could last for some test period, or it could be a permanent plan. (This would extend a path we've already travelled, including the one Larks & Ravens workshop at Pigtown Fling 2019, and the monthly Gender-Free Contra Dance that ran for 8 months or so.)
- 6) Add gender-free dances, but don't change the language at any of our standard scheduled dances.
- 7) Let the gender-free dance evolve organically as a separate, independent new dance form.
- 8) Move the existing Gender-Free Contra Dance under the Cincinnati Contra Dancers umbrella, forming a Gender-Free Dance Committee that Liz Burkhart volunteers to head. This involves adding a Larks & Ravens dance that caters to LGBTQ+ folks, once every 3 months to start. Frequency could rise depending on attendance. Gender-Free dances would not replace existing Monday or 2nd Saturday dances, which would use gendered language. Decide whether to keep finances separate or entangle them.
- 9) Call as in modern square dance: Each couple is referred to as a 1 or a 2. Everyone has a partner, a neighbor and an opposite. (The opposite is your neighbor's partner, traditionally of the same role as you.) Also your next neighbor, your last neighbor, your Shadow, your Trail Buddy. Refer to lefts and rights if needed. (Such as the left's roll their rights away with a half sashay. Or rights begin a full hey.)

Proposals for Related Outcomes

- 10) Provide notice ahead of time to the dancers saying what calling language will be used at each dance. But know that last-minute emergency caller switches can lead to changes in caller language.
- 11) Do not subsidize an alternative group.
- 12) Incorporate a line where every Raven/Lady is an actual female & every Lark/Gent is an actual male. (This proposal can incorporate trans folks in the gender they identify with.) We can do this whether or not we change our calling language.
- 13) Regardless of other outcomes we choose: If there is more than one line at a dance, designate one line at a gender-free calling dance as a retro line, where men always dance on the left. AND at a gendered calling dance, designate one line as a shenanigans line where role-swapped dancing may be enjoyed.